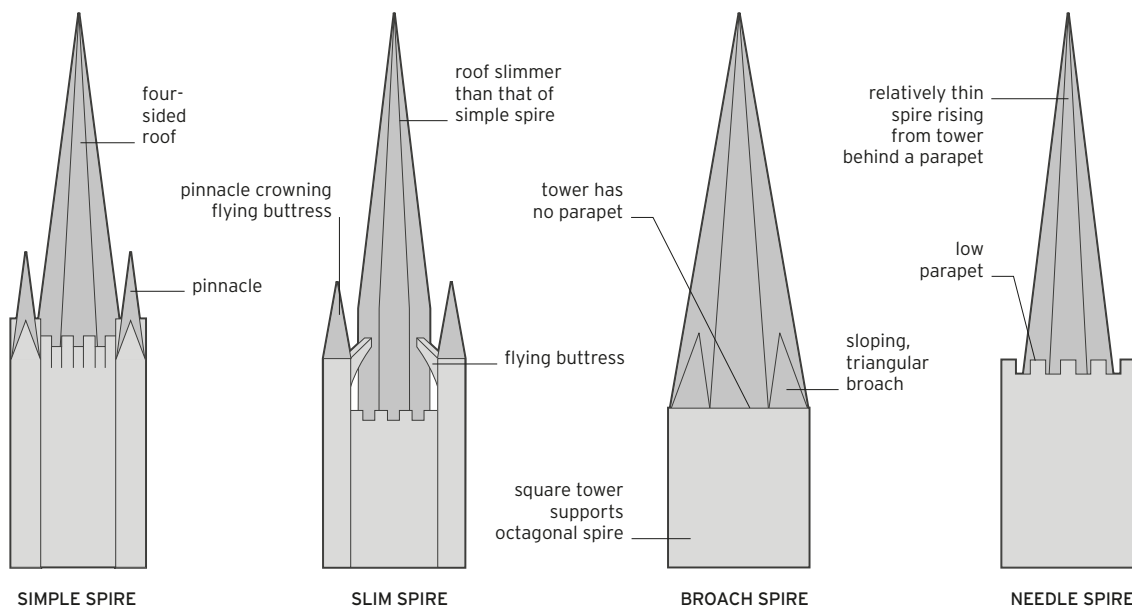


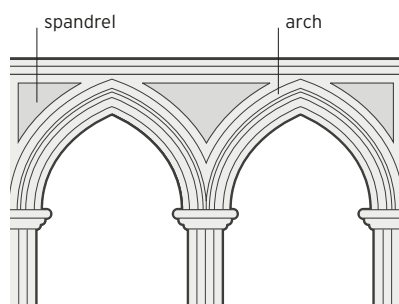
SPIRE

Most commonly associated with European Gothic architecture, the spire is a conical or multifaced tapering structure that provides the termination of a church or cathedral tower. The spire originated in the 12th century as a simple, four-sided pyramidal roof capping a tower, which over time developed into an ever higher, slimmer structure. Spires also became

increasingly ornate with the addition of broaches (triangular sections of masonry added to the bottom of the spire faces that did not coincide with the tower sides), gabled dormers, flying buttresses, and additional pinnacles around the base of the spire. The aim was always the same: to symbolize the heavenly aspirations of those who worshipped within the building.

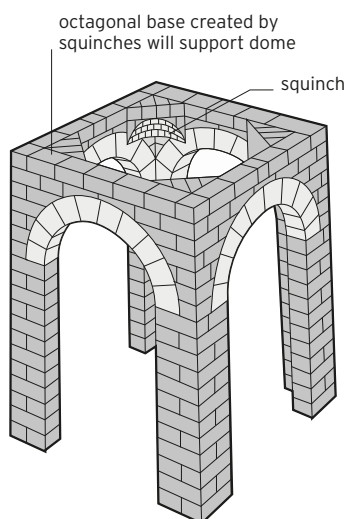


SPANDREL ▼ The space between a curved figure and a rectangular boundary—for example, the roughly triangular areas above and on either side of an arch and below a horizontal line aligned with the arch's apex. In modern times, a spandrel is also the area between the top of a window and the sill of the window above it.



SPIRE See panel, above.

SPRINGING LINE The point at which an arch starts to curve from its vertical supports. *See also* arch.



SQUINCH ▲ A corner filler of masonry placed diagonally at the interior angle of a square structure to create an octagonal upper space on which a dome can sit. The squinch evolved into the more sophisticated pendentive. *See also* pendentive.

STAR VAULT A type of rib vault in which secondary ribs connect with the main ribs to form a star pattern. *See also* rib vault.

STAVE A vertical wooden post or plank.

STELA A stone or wooden slab that is taller than it is wide. A stela generally has carved or painted text or ornamentation and serves as a monument, boundary marker, or official notice.

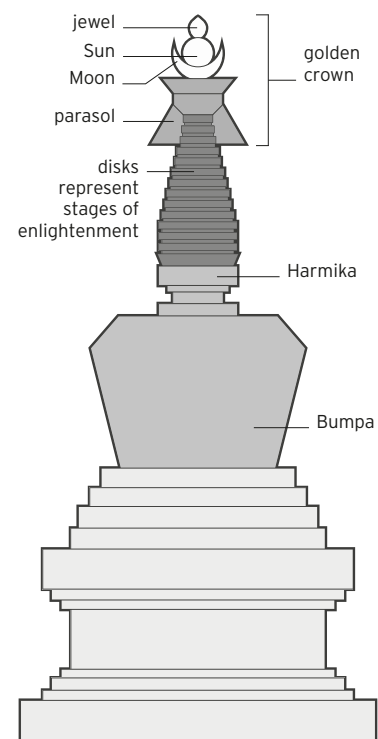
STOA In ancient Greek architecture, a covered walkway with the roof supported by one or more colonnades. Stoa often surrounded marketplaces.

STRAPWORK A form of decoration that makes ribbonlike elements into geometric patterns, usually within a frame. These elements are slightly raised on a flat surface, and strapwork is usually done in wood, metal, or plaster.

STUCCO A type of plaster that is applied wet and carved, often with highly elaborate designs. It is common in the Islamic architecture

of North Africa. Baroque and Rococo architecture also make heavy use of carved stucco in decorative interiors. *See also* Baroque, Rococo.

STUPA ▼ A Buddhist shrine for the veneration of saints, as well as the Buddha himself. The design of a stupa is derived from a burial mound and sometimes takes the form of a hemispherical dome topped by a small square structure. With the spread of Buddhism to Tibet, Nepal, and Sri Lanka, the stupa also evolved, in structure and symbolism, into an elongated cone with horizontal rings that typified stages of enlightenment. Stupas are not entered; instead, worship takes the form of walking around the monument in a clockwise direction.



STYLE The appearance of a building and, in particular, the features that identify it as belonging to a specific historical period or approach to design and construction.

STYLOBATE The top step of the stepped platform on which an ancient Greek temple was built.